

or musicians obsolete. Instead, they changed the way musical compositions were rendered or recorded. Gone are the days when an entire orchestra had to be in the recording studio or near a stage along with the singer.

The music from a synthesiser may have been artificially generated. But as the data set was limited, even a skilled musician needed to leverage considerable artistry to create good music. With AI-generated content, the scales have tilted far too much to the other side. Skill is not in great demand because the data set is so unbelievably big. Now, anyone can generate good content at the click of a button.

Why would someone hire a butler if the butler is going to issue voice commands and make a robot do all the work? It would be better to buy the robot and eliminate the butler! Similarly, why should someone pay a writer if an AI chatbot is doing all the heavy lifting? Here's the big difference.

When a writer uses AI to 'enhance' his writing, he is copying from several other writers. That collective Frankenstein writer is the real author who should get the credit. Search engines have scraped content from thousands of writers to create this monster. The generated content is not theirs to claim. Trying to make money from that is unlawful. It is as if you have used an electronic synthesiser that has an illegal sound bank of human voices. The fact that the software is or was open source is immaterial. The ultimate use-case is nefarious.

Where AI-generated content is (not) a problem

Recently, at a fashion show in New York, a prankster strode the ramp wearing a transparent garbage bag as a top and the clueless fashionistas who had assembled there did not notice anything amiss. It was the rent-a-cop bouncers who tackled him out of stage. Nevertheless, people do value original work. When someone buys a painting, he expects the painting to have been drawn by an artist. That is, a real human. The buyer would feel like his purse was burgled if he were to learn that the painting was AI-generated.

When you buy a book, the covers can be AI-generated. That is not a problem. What matters is the text between the covers. That should be written by a human through and through.

I frequently read reports about the performance of stock market scrips. A lot of articles are based on stock movements and publicly disclosed financial data. Because this data is highly structured, the article content seems to follow a pattern. They seem to be AI-written but there may be no AI or very little AI involved. It could be just mail-merge, a killer technology that made WordStar of the DOS command-line era famous. As a casual reader, I do not care if it was AI-generated. The content is free and I have no complaints.

Question thyself

YouTube is littered with misguided writing coaches who are advising budding writers to use AI to enhance their writing.

They are careful to say that if you do not have talent, AI cannot help you. However, if you have talent (please ... do not ask what talent), AI can make you a great writer. But, this cannot be true. AI will not make anyone a great writer. A dumb writer remains a dumb writer. He will just be plagiarising from several great writers. The AI software conveniently obfuscates the plagiarising part.

If you are a writer or a publisher and you wish to be paid for your content, ask yourself:

What is your value proposition?

- Will your readers like it if they were fooled by your AI-generated content?
- Will a reader want to pay good money for content that they can also generate?

How honest is your writing?

- Is it not your obligation to provide your own writing?
- Is it not misrepresentation to pass off AI-generated or AI-enhanced content as your own?
- Do you want to contaminate your writing with content or style stolen from other writers without their consent?

Why even write?

- Would it be not an abject admission that you are sub-par to a machine?
- Is this just a hustle or do you have some self-worth as a writer?

Despite the popularity of open source software, there is universal reticence among developers not to work with code developed by others. Even minor differences in the code formatting style or the naming convention for variables can put off other developers. I have used open source code numerous times in the software that I have developed but in all those cases I did not want to edit the foreign code by hand. I just packaged that code in an external library of routines that was separate from my own code. Most developers are like that. It is because we attach great pride and value to our own code that we create such boundaries. However, we cannot create such boundaries when we work in a team. Left to ourselves, we do not want someone else to interfere in our work as we want to hog all the credit. This is true of all professionals, not just software developers. No grownup wants a nanny.

The bottomline: do not contaminate your brand with AI. 

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